

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART TWO · CRAFT

CHAPTER 5 · EDITING

*Editing is film's dark art. Every cut decides what you see,
and what you don't.*

SUNSET BLVD.

The Witch · 2015 · 92 min · written and directed by Robert
Eggers · A24 · watch with subtitles on

*This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some
information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you
press play" and resume after the credits.*

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner. This one is watched over Halloween.

Two witch films, one question: when does the film cut to the witch? The Blair Witch Project never does. It pretends nobody edited it at all — three students' lost tapes — and every cut keeps the thing in the woods out of frame to the last shot.

The Witch is cut like a classic, slow and patient and nearly invisible, and it shows you the witch about ten minutes in. One hides her with the edit. The other reveals her with it. Both want you afraid of the same woods.

SUNSET BLVD.

THE VVITCH

2015 · 92 min · written and directed by Robert Eggers · A24 · watch with subtitles on

New England, the 1630s. A Puritan family is banished from their settlement and builds a farm at the edge of a forest. Then the baby disappears.

Why it is on the ballot. Where *Blair Witch* hides everything, this film shows you the witch almost immediately and is still one of the most frightening films of the century. The cutting is patient and nearly invisible, and the fear comes from watching a family fall apart while you already know what is in the woods.

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

Optional trivia.

TURN THE SUBTITLES ON

Much of the dialogue comes from period journals, diaries and court records — the film says so in its closing titles — and it is spoken in Early Modern English. It is beautiful and hard to catch by ear.

IT IS A FIRST FILM, SHOT IN 25 DAYS FOR ABOUT \$3.5 MILLION

Robert Eggers's debut feature and Anya Taylor-Joy's first leading role. It premiered at Sundance in January 2015, where Eggers won the U.S. Dramatic directing award, and reached cinemas a year later. The full title is stylised *The VVitch: A New-England Folktale*, the double-V borrowed from Jacobean witchcraft pamphlets.

LIT BY THE SKY AND BY CANDLES

Shot near Kiosk in remote northern Ontario. Cinematographer Jarin Blaschke used only natural light outdoors, with the schedule bent around keeping the sky overcast, and real candlelight indoors. The darkness is real darkness.

WHILE YOU WATCH

Open each one only when you reach it.

ABOUT TEN MINUTES IN

Peekaboo

A girl plays with the baby at the edge of the trees. Hands over eyes. Hands away.

Why it matters: The film's whole editing philosophy is in one game. Every cut is a hand over your eyes, and every time the hands come away, something has changed.

RIGHT AFTER

The film shows you

Where Blair Witch would cut away, this film cuts into the woods and shows you what happened to him.

Why it matters: The chapter's question is answered in the first act. From here the horror is not whether she is real, it is watching a family who cannot see what you have seen. Eggers calls it "the big early reveal."

THE ANIMALS

Watch what the edit keeps cutting to

A hare. A goat. A raven. The film keeps leaving the family for an animal that is watching them.

Why it matters: An edit can accuse. Every cutaway points at something and asks you to suspect it. Eggers deliberately buried the goat's importance in the cut — when investors said they could not tell the goat mattered, he said "Good, I don't want people to know the goat is important."

THE LAST SCENE

Into the woods

After ninety minutes of cutting around the forest, the film finally goes all the way in.

Why it matters: The edit has held the forest at arm's length the whole time. When it stops, the film is over.

AFTER THE CREDITS

Everything here gives the film away. Keep it for afterwards.

OPEN

Everything the family fears is real

Eggers has described the film as a Puritan nightmare told on its own terms: the witch, the devil and the curse are not metaphors, because to this family they were not. The dialogue and the beliefs come out of the records of the period.

OPEN

The witch is on screen before the family suspects anything

The reveal after Samuel vanishes — the knife, the ointment — is an editorial decision, not a horror beat. The film gives away its secret in the first act and then makes you sit with a household of people who do not know it.

OPEN

“Wouldst thou like to live deliciously?”

The film’s most quoted line is five words from a goat, and it was everywhere online the year the film came out. Eggers went on to make *The Lighthouse*, *The Northman* and *Nosferatu*.

- 01 The film shows you the witch in the first act. Did knowing she was real make it scarier, or less?
- 02 The family turns on each other long before anything supernatural finishes them. Who is the real threat?
- 03 Blair Witch cuts away. The Witch holds the shot. Which one frightened you more, and why?

Where to watch

Find it here → [The Witch on JustWatch](#), which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones.

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

Sources: [Variety](#) · [Slate](#) · [Birth.Movies.Death](#)

THE CUT SHOULD DISAPPEAR

EDITORS WORKED IT OUT BY HAND

Through the first half of the twentieth century, Hollywood editors built a set of habits for joining shots so smoothly that nobody noticed the joins. Cut in the middle of a movement. Keep the camera on one side of the action. Match where people are looking. None of it was law. It was craft, passed from editor to assistant.

A BRITISH BOOK WROTE IT DOWN

In 1953 Karel Reisz, working with a committee of the British Film Academy chaired by Thorold Dickinson, published *The Technique of Film Editing*, which collected what working editors actually did. It became the standard textbook for decades and taught the habits as the rules of **continuity editing**, with one goal stated plainly: the audience should never notice the cut.

MEANWHILE, IN MOSCOW

Thirty years earlier Lev Kuleshov had intercut one neutral close-up of the actor Ivan Mosjoukine with a bowl of soup, a girl in a coffin and a woman on a divan. Audiences praised the actor's range for hunger, grief and desire. The face never changed; the cut did all the work. Worth knowing that the footage is lost and the story comes to us second-hand through Pudovkin's 1929 account, and that a 1992 attempt to replicate it failed. The idea survived anyway, because every horror film runs on it.

THREE WAYS TO CUT

ONE

CONTINUITY

Smooth, invisible joins that keep you inside the story.

Almost every Hollywood film
· The Witch

TWO

COLLISION

Shots slammed together so the meaning comes from the clash rather than from either shot.

Battleship Potemkin · the
Psycho shower · Requiem
for a Dream

THREE

THE CUT THAT SHOWS

Jump cuts, black screens, a camera switching off. The edit is on display.

Breathless · The Blair Witch
Project · Uncut Gems

A horror film usually runs on the first and the third at once: invisible cutting to keep you inside, and one visible cut to make you jump.

HOW LONG IS A SHOT?

Editing has one number attached to it that anybody can check: the average shot length, the runtime divided by the number of shots. It will not tell you whether a film is any good, but it will tell you how hard it is working to hold you, and it separates eras more cleanly than almost anything else you can measure.



2s

4s

6s

8s

10s

12s

14s

SIXTY SECONDS OF SCREEN TIME, CUT SIX WAYS

2.4 seconds a shot · *The Bourne Supremacy*, 2004



4.7 seconds a shot · *Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind*, 2004



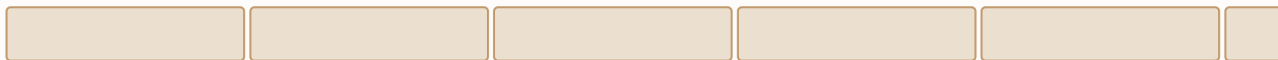
7.1 seconds a shot · *The Blair Witch Project*, 1999



9.5 seconds a shot · *Touch of Evil*, 1958



11.4 seconds a shot · *Citizen Kane*, 1941



13.5 seconds a shot · *The Witch*, 2015



The pale notches are published counts. The two in orange are this chapter's own films, timed in house rather than taken from anyone's table. Everything bunches between five and nine seconds, which is most of cinema; the room either side of that bunch is where a film is doing something deliberate.

ONE PIECE OF VOCABULARY

The **Kuleshov effect**: viewers read emotion into a shot based on the shot beside it. A face, then the dark, and you decide what the face saw.

WHY THESE FILMS

Chapter 4 decided what goes in the frame. This chapter decides what happens between frames. Blair Witch hides its edits and its witch. The Witch hides neither, and dares you to stay frightened anyway.

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R. Julian Tuttle

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from Variety, the AV Club, Film Stories, Slate, Box Office Mojo and interviews with the filmmakers. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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